

Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS** / AI

Gibsonian world where utopia and dystopia both exist, and the distances between them are growing larger. So in countries like India, the question is not what the tech is or what it is potentially capable of. What's of much greater urgency is to understand how it will be used, how it affects different strata of society, and how it intersects with our incredible mix of political, social, cultural and economic crises. What is being promised at each level of privilege? And what is demanded in exchange? Just as surveillance is sold on the promise of security and then delivers social control and data grabs, AI is also being sold on certain promises and will deliver other things. Your experience with AI tools will depend on whether you're the sort of person who gives up their face data willingly to find out what celeb they look like, or have their face data taken from them by policemen while standing on a road. No doubt AI-augmented technology will create efficiencies and spectacular leaps in some lives. But whose?

The most urgent issue with AI is that in the present era, the technojoy that results from the AI-future presentations leads to businesses embracing very primitive AI as a cost-cutting tool. The primal technofear about AI/ robots is that they would replace humans in society. That's not a present-day problem, but we already have an unemployment crisis, and the promise of cost-saving with AI tools is only going to make it worse. In the fields

TAKEAWAYS

AI is a dream humans have had since ancient times, which is why there are automata, mechanical beings and intelligent objects in the myths of most ancient cultures

AI is an amazing tool only in a world where human systems already fundamentally work, a utopia where humans create art and experience leisure, while machines do the humdrum stuff

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